

“Take the dung of a dog-faced baboon, two eggs of an ibex, four drams of frankincense, a single onion. Put all these onto a mortar with the mouse.”

GREEK MAGICAL PAPYRUS

to various remedies to secure the favor of Eros, the god of love, or, more darkly, of Hecate, the goddess of witchcraft. First on their list was magic, in all its guises.

Tools of magic

Certain stones were believed to possess magical powers, such as hematite (bloodstone), thought to protect unborn babies, and light-green jasper, used to cure stomach infections. These were set into amulets of wood, bone, or stone that the supplicant could wear. Sailors about to embark on a hazardous voyage might have made use of a protective pendant depicting Poseidon (god of the sea), trident in hand and foot on a dolphin, or those in fear of the *baskania* (the evil eye) might have employed an eye-shaped pendant to ward off its gaze.

Books of spells laid down the rituals to be carried out in the creation of amulets, involving incantations and hand gestures. Many amulets were inscribed with anagrams or palindromes of gods' names, or were lodged in locket with papyrus texts containing mythical narratives.

Various implements completed the magician's ritual toolkit, from wands, such as that of mythical enchantress Circe, to polished stones, mirrors, water basins, cymbals, harps, and the *rhombos*, a spinner used to amplify magical power. Magicians also employed *pharmaka* (potions)—in the *Odyssey*, Odysseus takes one made from moly (a magical herb) to stop Circe from turning him into a pig. *Pharmaka* were supplemented by *philtia* (love potions and poisons). The latter appeared in the myths of Hercules: Deianeira, the hero's wife, accidentally killed her husband when she smeared his cloak with a *philtia*—the blood of the centaur Nessus.



► Medea the sorceress

This vase depicts Medea demonstrating her skill by dismembering and boiling an old ram. The magical herbs in the cauldron bring it back to life and restore its youth.